COACHING MODULE



SELBORNE COLLEGE RUGBY CLUB

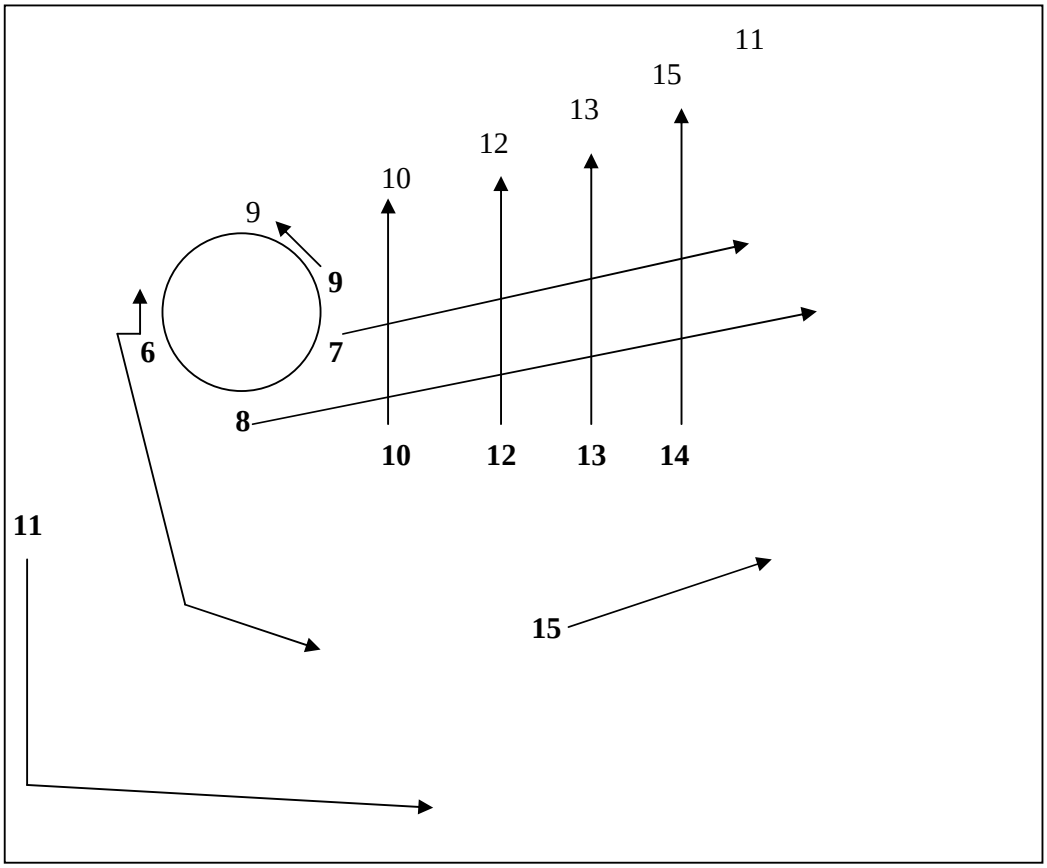
Module 2: **Defence**

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DEFENSIVE PATTERNS:

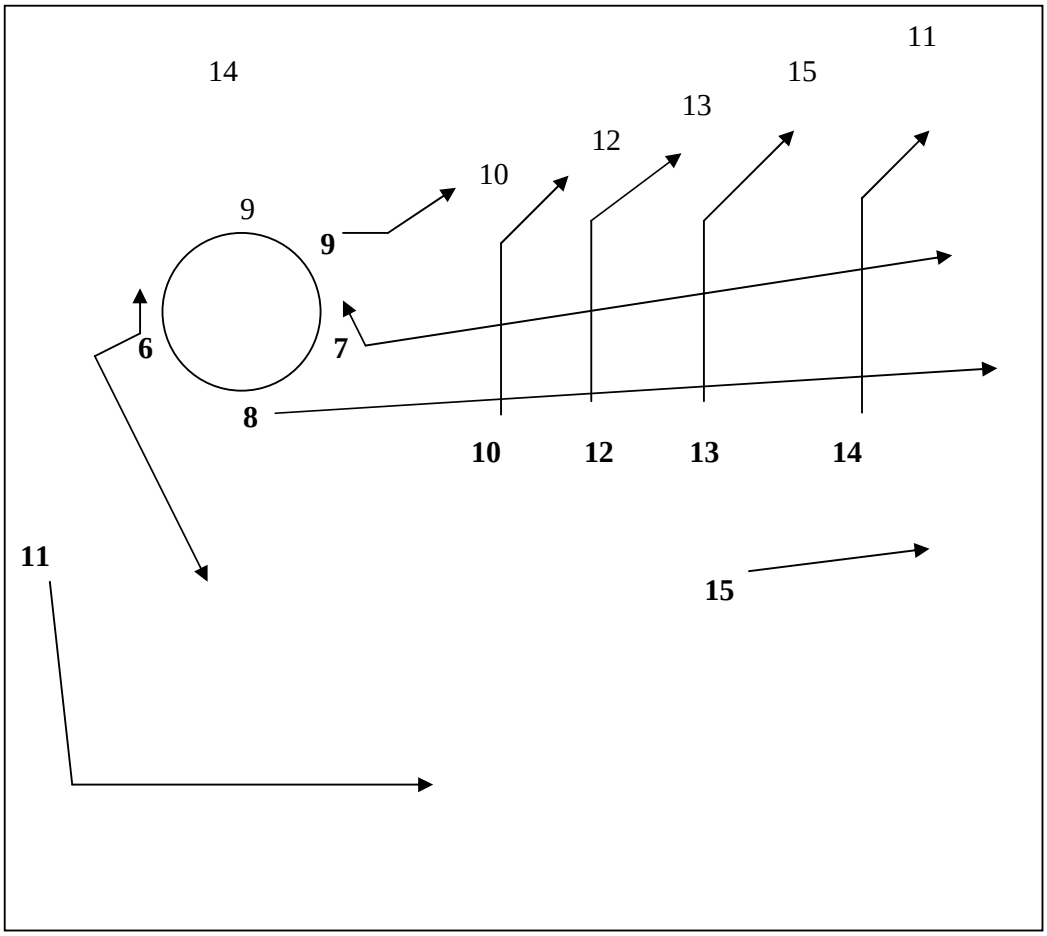
Defence from a Left Scrum:

A. *Man on Man*:



9 goes for his opposite number first and then moves behind his backline covering any missed tackles.
7 first covers the inside of 10 and then moves across the field behind his backs. He must always stay in the inside of the ball, so he can cover the inside gaps.
8 moves straight across the field behind the backs, watching for any missed tackles.
6 must first check if they are going blind. He must support 11 if they kick or cross cover.
11 falls back deep for the box kick and then moves across the field after their flyhalf has passed.
Backline must tackle man on man from the inside. They must come up together.
Tight Forwards 3, **2** and **5** take the shortest route and **1** and **4** take a slightly deeper route to the ball.

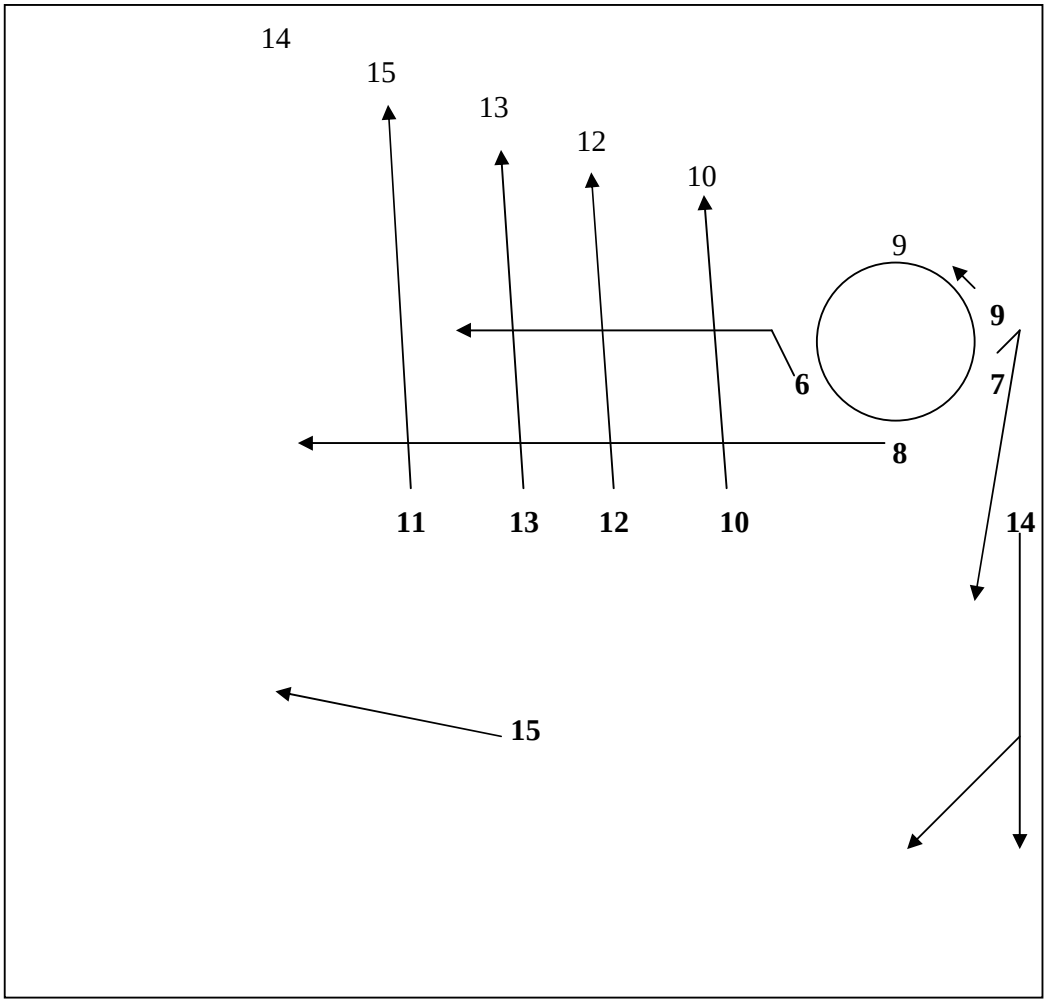
B. *Drift Defence*:



9 moves away from the scrum and takes their 10 and then puts the rest of their backline under pressure (he is only allowed to move 1m away, but play the ref).
Backline shifts one down and comes up together. They must stay in their channels.
7 watches their 9 and then moves across the field closing all inside gaps behind his backline.
8 also moves across the field watching for inside gaps and staying on the inside of the ball.
6 watches the blind and then falls back deep. If there is no kick he cross covers.
11 still watches for the box kick and then moves across the field watching for missed tackles or kicks.
15 always covers 2/3 of the field and the other 1/3 is covered by the wing.
Tight Forwards the same.

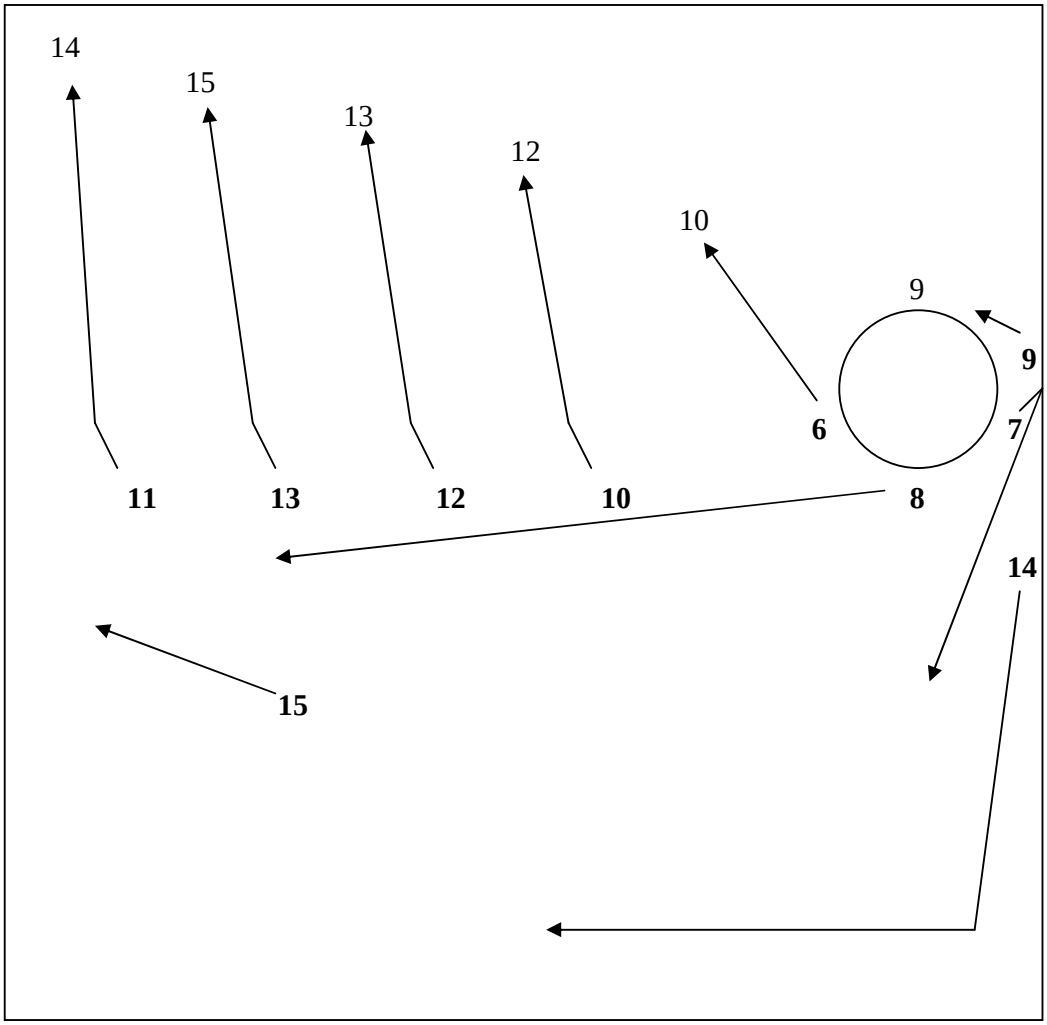
Defence from a Right Scrum:

A. *Man on Man*:



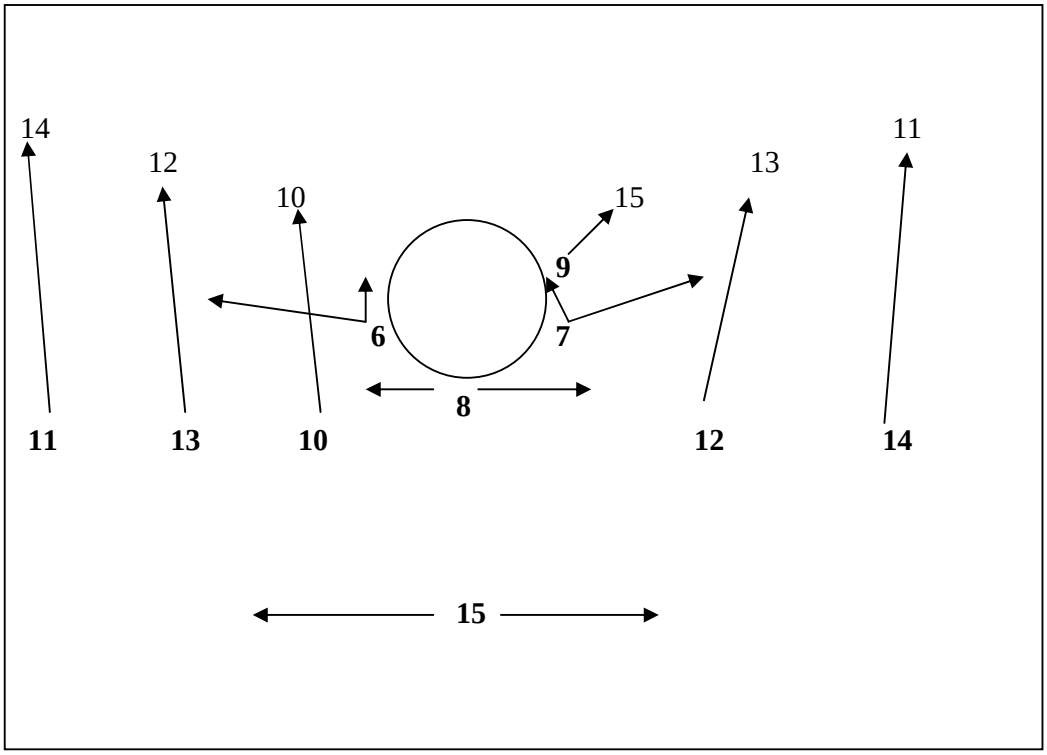
9 applies pressure on his opposite number and also on their 10 if he is standing deep or he moves around the back of his scrum and cover defends.
6 watches for a break around the scrum and then stays on the inside of his 10, until their 10 has passed. He then stays on the inside of the ball covering behind his backline.
Backline takes man on man from the inside and stay in their channels.
8 comes across the field (not over running the ball) watching for any breaks or kicks.
14 falls back deep watching for a box kick. After their 10 has passed he moves across the field.
7 makes sure that they are not going blind and then falls back deep. If there is no kick he cross covers.
Tight Forwards on the left **1**, **2** and **4** take the shortest root and the right **3** and **5** take deeper root.

B. *Drift Defence*:



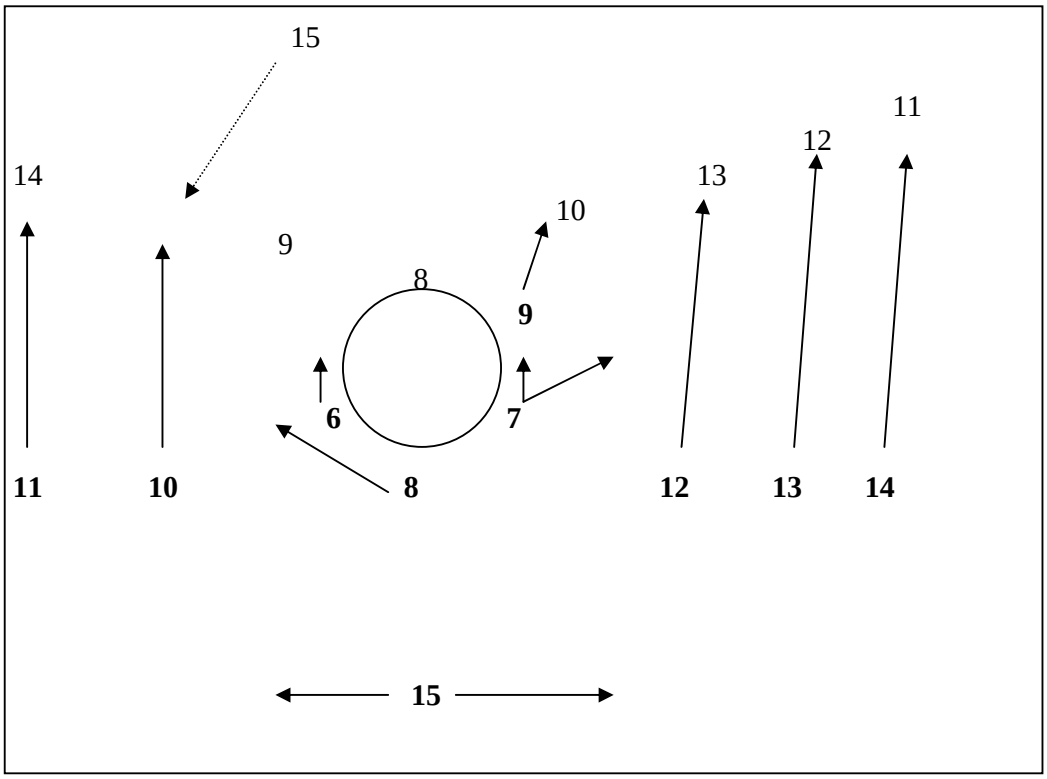
9 does the same as man on man defence from a right scrum.
10 moves across the field and takes their inside centre from the inside.
Backline also moves across the field. They take their men from the inside and stay in their channels.
6 takes their 10 and then moves across the field covering the inside gaps.
8 first covers the inside gap between their 9 and 10 and then cross covers.
7 and **14** do the same as above.
Tight Forwards do the same.

Defence from a Midfield Scrum:



9 will always takes the first man on the right.
10 will always take 10 on the left.
Backline always takes their man.
15 covers either side.
Flankers will always watch for the pick up and then cover the first channel to the scrum or fall back deep. They then move across the field covering the inside gaps.
Wings will either be taking their man or falling back a bit for the box kick before cross covering. The outside man is always his man.
Tight Forwards: the three closest to the ball take the shortest route and the other two take a deeper route.

Big blind on the Left:

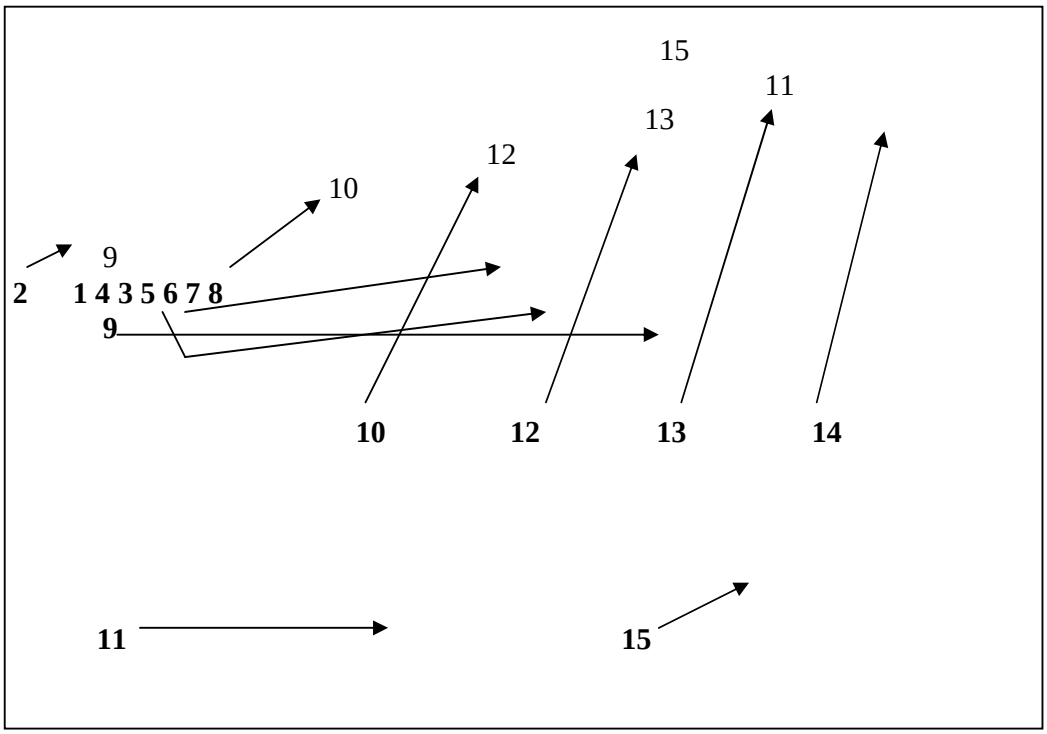


10 will leave 9 for **8** and take 15.
8 take 9.

Coaching Tip:
You can put the scrumhalf the back of the scrum as long as he is behind the No.8's feet. This could be a good tactic to use when you know that they might be attacking close to the scrum. The flank, the No.8 and scrumhalf can then cover the inside of the flyhalf.

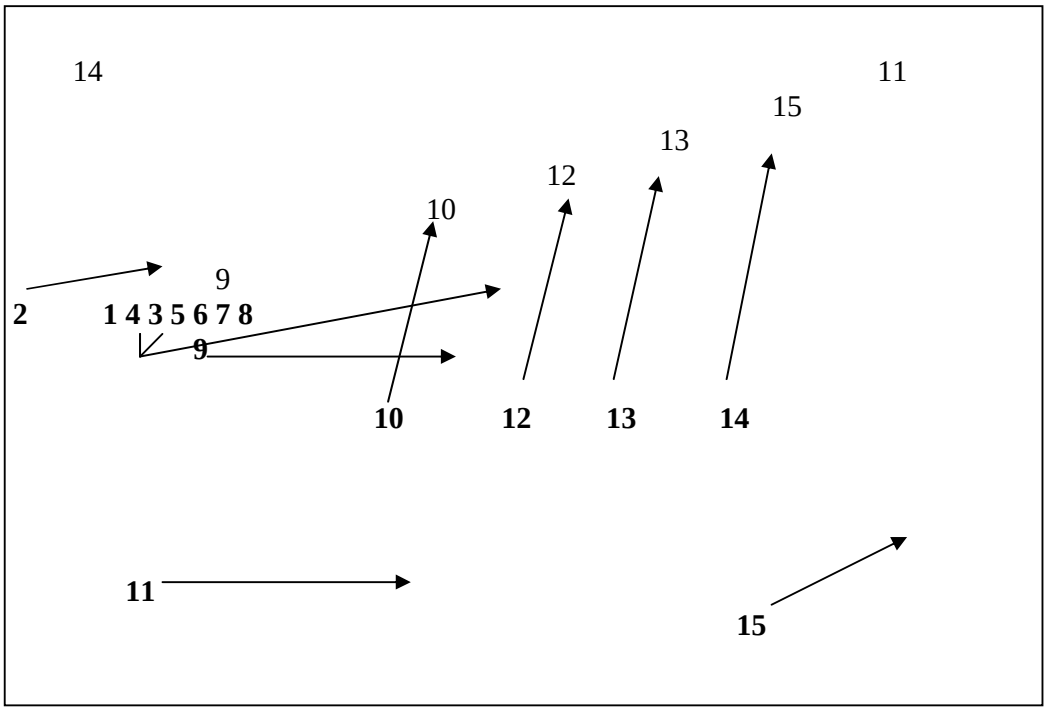
Defence from the Line out:

A. *When the ball goes to 2 or 4*:



Loose Forwards are in the game so they can defend.
8 takes 10 and then covers the inside gaps.
7 moves across the field staying on the inside of the ball watching for any inside breaks just in front of the advantage line.
6 moves across the field along the advantage line, staying on the inside of the ball.
9 also moves across the field behind the advantage line, watching for any chips.
11 checks for the box kick and then cross covers.
2 applies pressure on 9 and then comes across. If they drive he stands off on the blind.
Tight Forwards take the shortest root to the ball while covering the blind together.

B. *When the ball goes to the back*:



Loose forwards are out of it, but must work hard to get back into the game.
Backline tackles man on man.
Tight Forwards must try and watch the inside gaps while cross covering.
11 does the same as above.
2 also does the same as above.

If there is a short lineout our forwards must defend against their forwards standing off. Remember that there are no numbers in the lineout anymore. The minimum is two and you can have as many numbers as you like. We should always set up two pods regardless of their formation. The first pod covers the front and the second pod covers the middle and the back.

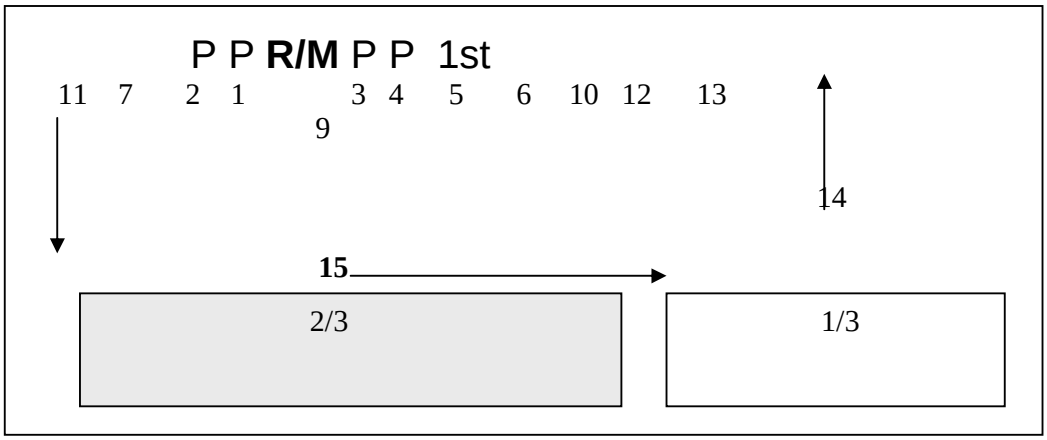
Special Line out Defence:

Put the fastest loose forward in the backline. He gets used to rush/pressurise their 10 or centre. As soon as the ball is tapped, he goes as fast as he can. The backs defend as usual behind him.

Or play this loose forward at scrumhalf and let him stand at the back of the lineout. He will then have less distance to cover.

'Sacking' can be used to defend a drive, remember to coach your players to collapse. This is now allowed as long as it is from the below the shoulders and above the hips.

Defence in Open Play:



Pillars: 1 and 3 (Outside foot up, look at the ball and glance at the opponents)
Must watch for a pick and go and then cover inside of the Post.
Pillar must make sure that everyone is behind the last mans feet at the ruck.

Posts: 2 and 4 (Outside foot up)
Watch for a break by the scrumhalf and then cover the inside of the 1st defender.
The Post man shouts "Hold, hold, …" while watching the scrumhalf and the ball.
Once the ball is in play he shouts "Press!" or "Rush!" and the rest of the defensive line comes up together, while making sure that their inside defender is slightly in front of them.

1st Defender: The 1st Defender (inside leg up) tackles the first receiver. If the 1st receiver passes the ball he then covers the inside of the next defender i.e. turns the corner. He must communicate that the "first receiver is mine!"

All Defenders: It is important that your inside defender is in front of you.

The tight forwards must always work their way in, to defend around the ruck or maul. We don't want tight forwards defending the opposition's backs, but it can often happen and this is why everyone needs to be able to defend.
The "Pillar" and "Post" must take up their positions as soon as possible. They always go up straight and move (turn the corner) after the 2nd pass to shut out the inside gaps. They continue pushing until the 4th pass.
Players must be behind the last mans feet at the ruck.
New defenders file in on the outside of the 1st defender.
The inside defender must always watch for the inside step by the next attacking player after his man has passed (turning the corner).
Remember that to be beaten on the outside the attacker has to be really quick, this is why they often step back inside.

REMEMBER TO COMMUNICATE!

Defence in General:

It is obvious that rugby players prefer attack to defense, but by spending extra time on defense, your attack can actually improve. There are a number of different tackling techniques, which need to be used depending on the defensive situation.

1. **Riding the tackle** can be used when a defender sees that the attacker is going to ground on his own caused by momentum. An example could be when your opponent is running at you and you are stationery and have little momentum you can grab his jersey and pull him down (this is known as 'riding the tackle'). Here you have used his momentum to bring him down and you steal the ball or slow it down. I have coached my players to go to ground, fall on top of the attacker, and grab the ball while getting up. This allows the defender to be in his strongest body position to steal the ball (chest over the ball) and to be cleaned out with the ball.
2. **Tackling the ball (smother tackle)** is another technique that can be used when your attacker has not had enough time to get momentum. The defender must make sure that he has a defender on his inside and outside shoulder. Tackle the ball in an upward movement. It is an easier target than his legs and can't mislead you, but watch out for the hand off. This technique will also prevent the attacker from getting the offload. Wrap your arms around the ball and remember to get your feet close.
3. The **two man tackle** can be used to tackle a player backwards. Here two defenders work together. One defender takes the opponent low while the other defender takes him above the waist (tackling the ball). Drive attacker back.
4. The **twist tackle**, is a technique that has picked up plenty of flack in the previous season. The technique is as follows: get your lead foot close to the defender, arms out, get contact with the shoulder, while clamping arms lift the opponent's leg and twist him off balance all in the same movement. If you hit with the right shoulder, you lead with the right leg and your left arm is used to lift the opponent's leg and twist. The tackler who should fall on top of the attacker must get back to his feet to steal the ball.
5. **Fulcrum tackle**, has been developed as a safer option than the twist technique. This technique also relies on the defender to get close to the attacker. The clamping and squeezing of the arms around the waist of the attacker is used to immobilise.
6. **Three point stance** can be used when you are defending close to your try line or to the ruck. The defender gets into a low body position with one hand on the ground. You tackle from a low body position, driving up and forward.
7. **Low tackle**, the most common error in all defensive work is the failure to clamp the arms around the attacking player. This is important when performing a low tackle.
8. **Side tackle**, players must remember to not wait for the attacker to come to them. Keep your eyes open, head up and out of the way, get your feet close (no missile tackling) and wrap arms around the target.
9. **Tackle from behind**, aim for contact just below the hips and clamp the arms.

Some Important Points:

- Always keep your opponent on your outside. This will mean that you will have less distance to cover and will need less speed.
- Tackle inside hip.
- Keep your eyes open at all times!
- Keep your hands below your shoulders, just above your hips. Remember by opening your arms apart, it makes the space look smaller to the attacker.
- Depending on the situation you should never give your opponent time or space. Go to him don't let him come to you.
- No studs showing and get your feet close to the attacker, arms up, hit with the shoulder, clamp arms and lift opposite leg and twist.
- No missile tackling.
- Remember to 'turn the corner' and to always have your inside defender slightly in front of you.
- If there is an overlap don't chase the ball 'turn and burn'. If there is someone back as the last line of defence run for his inside shoulder.
- If you are ever in a 1 on 2 situation, never rush up, delay your commitment (drop off/pull back) to an attacker. This will give your team mates time to get back and to help by covering the inside.

You have to constantly be on your toes to react when defending. You must also have the correct stance on defence as well as the fact that once a pass has been made, the defender who was not on cue is not off the hook. You need to work! Still come up and watch the inside.

After making a tackle get back onto your feet as quickly as possible. If you are the tackler i.e. your knee has also touched the ground there is no gate / offsides line for you until the ruck has formed (a player from either team bound over the ball); so get to your feet and steal the ball. You can play it from anywhere. I think that this is an important skill/technique that the fullback should master, because they are often the last line of defense, hence that the ruck is often not formed, and they have time to steal the ball.

The roles and responsibilities at the breakdown are important, and a team needs to be technically astute and aggressive at the tackle ball area. If we dominate the collision area, it will buy time for the defense to dominate the next collision area. The majority of the game is spent in this area and if we can dominate here we will win any game.

Where was Henry Honibal's point of contact when his shoulders crashed into his opponents? It was just above the waist. This is the softest and most vulnerable area of your opponent. Why go for a hard, moving target like his legs (which can deceive you), if you can go for a soft stationery target. The most important things when tackling are: getting your feet close (studs on the ground for as long as possible), the contact with the shoulder, the clamping of the arms (fulcrum) and then driving the attacker back with leg power. (Eyes open, Feet close, Shoulder and Arms) If you can get the correct attitude in defence from your team they will be unrivalled.

Backline:

- Stay in your channels and come up together while making sure that you can see your inside defender.
- Vary the speed that you come up. This could confuse your opponents.
- Offensive defence (be aggressive)
- Communication
- Commitment

Forwards:

- 10m from our line we should never be contesting their lineout and watch for the drive or peel.
- It is important to get into defensive formation immediately from a set piece. From a lineout we should stay in the formation and cover that area, while pressing up and across.
- If they drive or maul remember low body positions and sack. Work together and try to isolate their ball carrier. Hit them hard and fast, drive them back and split them. Remember the 3 point stance.
- Tight forwards need to watch the first channel of the rucks.
- Loose forwards must stand out and mark their loose forwards. They must watch for the overlaps and work hard cross covering. Remember to watch the outside and inside channel of your flyhalf and to cover all the inside gaps.
- Offensive defence
- Communication
- Commitment

Coaching Tips: General Attacking Pointers

The last thing you want to do is go to ground on good attacking ball, especially if there is a lack of support.

Keep the ball alive and offload to a supporting player.

Getting slow ball at the breakdown often means that the team isn't dictating.

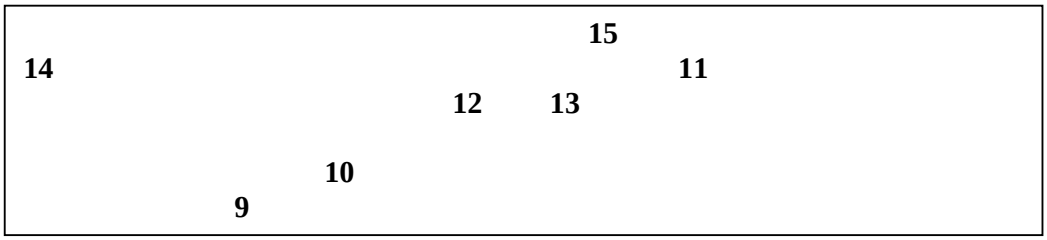
Ball presentation and winning the contact will determine if you get good attacking ball. You need to concentrate on doing the small things correctly in training because they can then become second nature in the game situation.

The more 'live' the contact is in training, the better prepared players are for the game situation.

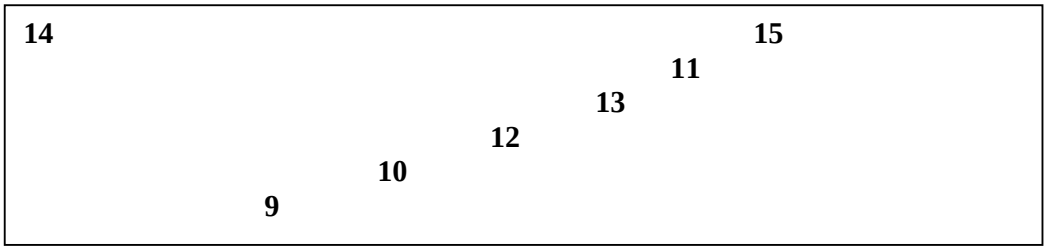
Use the area out wide e.g. 5m to touchline. If we put 3 players in this area and can offload it is almost certain that we will get through.

Encourage the players to work the blind.

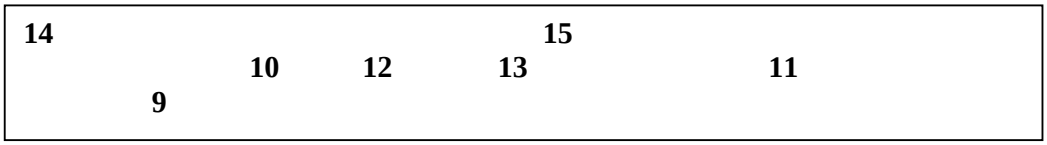
ANTICIPATING WHAT COULD HAPPEN FROM A LINEOUT OR SCRUM BY YOUR OPPONENT'S FORMATION:



10 *is shallow,* **12** *and blindside wing are deep*:
12 and **10** could be planning a move or
14 may be joining the line.



Backline is standing deep and **15** *is wide*:
Ball must be going wide.



The backline is standing shallow:
10 might kick or the forwards might pick up or drive.

Coaching Tip:

It is important to encourage your players to learn to see what is in front of them and to react accordingly.